in the time of both Xuanzang and Yijing.[22] Of course, it is hard for outsiders to grasp the intricacies of caste even today—especially if their native informants and interlocutors are the educated elite, which must surely have been the case with the Chinese pilgrims. That said, some aspects of caste are plainly evident in their accounts. Among the four varnas, writes Xuanzang, 'the purity or impurity of caste assigns to everyone his place'. Without elaboration, he also writes, 'When they marry they rise or fall in position according to their new relationship.'

Yijing writes, 'The Brahmans are regarded throughout the five parts of India as the most honorable [caste]. They do not, when they meet in a place, associate with the other three castes, and the mixed classes of the people have still less intercourse with them. The scriptures they revere are the four Vedas, containing about 100,000 verses . . . handed down from mouth to mouth, not transcribed on paper or leaves. In every generation, there exist some intelligent Brahmans who can recite the 100,000 verses.'[23] Faxian recalls one such renowned Brahmin turned Buddhist in Patliputra, Radhasami, who lived 'by himself in spotless purity'. He habitually washed his hands right after anyone touched them. One day, out of 'love and reverence', the king 'took hold of his hand'. A bemused Faxian adds that 'as soon as [the king] let it go, the Brahmin made haste to pour water on it and wash it'.

Towns across the country have 'wide and high' walls, writes Xuanzang, but does not say what fears led people to build them. These walls enclose tortuous streets and lanes. 'The thoroughfares are dirty' with 'stalls arranged on both sides of the road with appropriate signs'. Could the still filthy streets of modern Indian towns have such an ancient lineage? 'Butchers, fishers, dancers, executioners, and scavengers . . . have their abodes outside' the walls. 'In coming and going these persons are bound to keep on the left side of the road till they arrive at their homes.' Yijing, too, notes that manual scavengers, 'who carry off feces and clear away filth have to distinguish [i.e., announce] themselves by striking sticks while going about; when one has by mistake touched any of them, one thoroughly washed oneself and one's garments'. Untouchability was clearly an established practice in the seventh century.